

# Mobile Legends: Bang Bang's Russian community — aberration or real?

**Where this came from:** `notebooks/title_geography_maps.ipynb`'s language-mix choropleth showed Mobile Legends: Bang Bang mapping 89.9% Russian — surprising, since the game's publicly-understood competitive home is Southeast Asia. A first-pass check attributed it mostly to one live CIS-region tournament overlapping the capture window. That explanation didn't hold up under closer inspection (see that notebook's corrected note) — only ~10% of the Russian signal is tournament-tagged.

**This notebook asks the question properly, across every data source this project has that can speak to it:** is MLBB's Russian-language Twitch presence a real, representative community, or a short-window fluke — and just as importantly, **how big is it in absolute terms**, not only as a share of MLBB's own (fairly small) Twitch footprint. Share and absolute scale can tell very different stories, and both are answered here separately, not conflated.

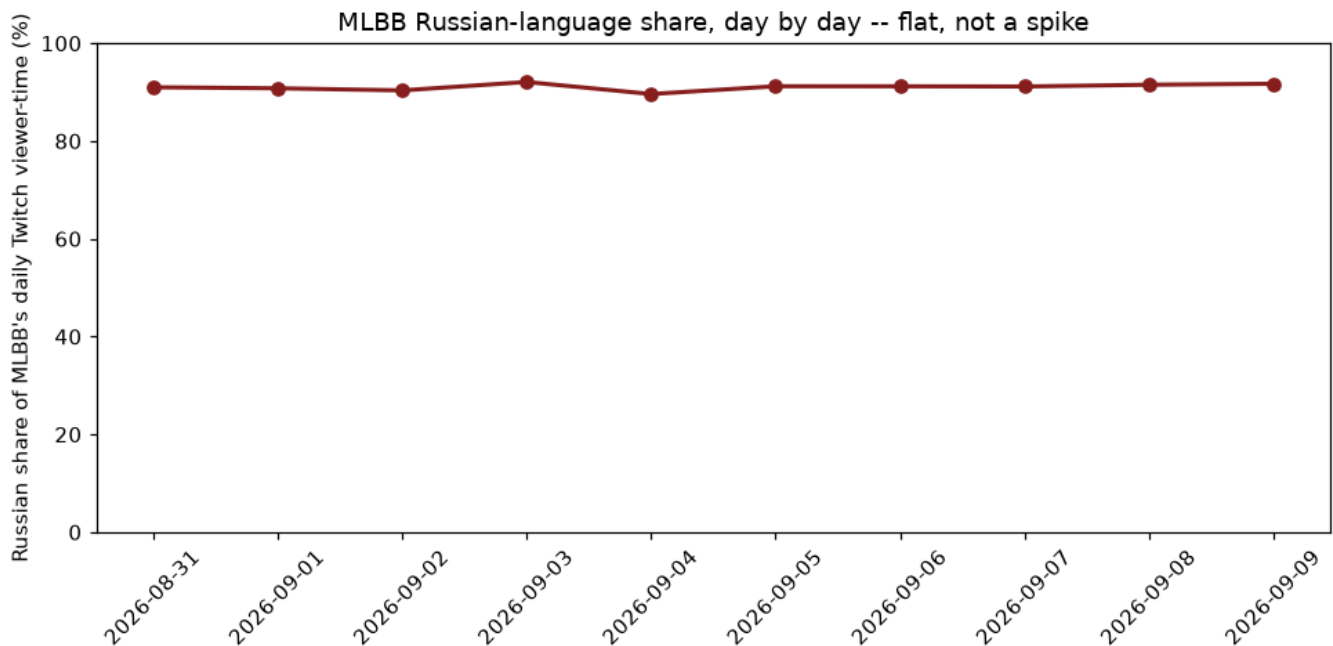
## 1. Share — how dominant is Russian within MLBB's own Twitch presence

Recap from `title_geography_maps.ipynb`, with the fuller detail behind the headline numbers.

MLBB total distinct channels (full-detail tier): 791  
MLBB Russian-language channels: 422 (53.4% of all MLBB channels)

|   | language | channels | viewer_time | channel_share_pct |
|---|----------|----------|-------------|-------------------|
| 0 | ru       | 422      | 153148      | 53.4              |
| 1 | en       | 137      | 7095        | 17.3              |
| 2 | es       | 108      | 2502        | 13.7              |
| 3 | pt       | 65       | 4215        | 8.2               |
| 4 | tl       | 14       | 277         | 1.8               |
| 5 | fr       | 9        | 151         | 1.1               |
| 6 | de       | 8        | 322         | 1.0               |
| 7 | th       | 7        | 124         | 0.9               |
| 8 | id       | 6        | 117         | 0.8               |
| 9 | other    | 4        | 78          | 0.5               |

**By raw creator-base size, not just viewer-time — Russian is the plurality language for MLBB on Twitch**, ahead of English, Spanish, and every Southeast Asian language combined (Tagalog, Thai, Indonesian together are under 30 channels, vs. 422 Russian ones).



day

```

2026-08-31    91.0
2026-09-01    90.8
2026-09-02    90.3
2026-09-03    92.1
2026-09-04    89.6
2026-09-05    91.2
2026-09-06    91.2
2026-09-07    91.1
2026-09-08    91.5
2026-09-09    91.7

```

Name: viewer\_time, dtype: float64

**Flat at 89.6%-92.1% across all 10 days** — no dip before the CIS tournament's window, no spike around it, no fade after. A tournament skewing a short sample would show up as a bump against a lower baseline; this shows no baseline to bump from — Russian dominance appears to simply be MLBB's steady state on Twitch throughout the whole window.

Total Russian viewer-time: 153148

Top 10 of 422 Russian channels: 78010 (50.9% of Russian total) -- broad, not whale-driven

Tournament-broadcast-tagged (detected\_costream): 16064 (10.5%)

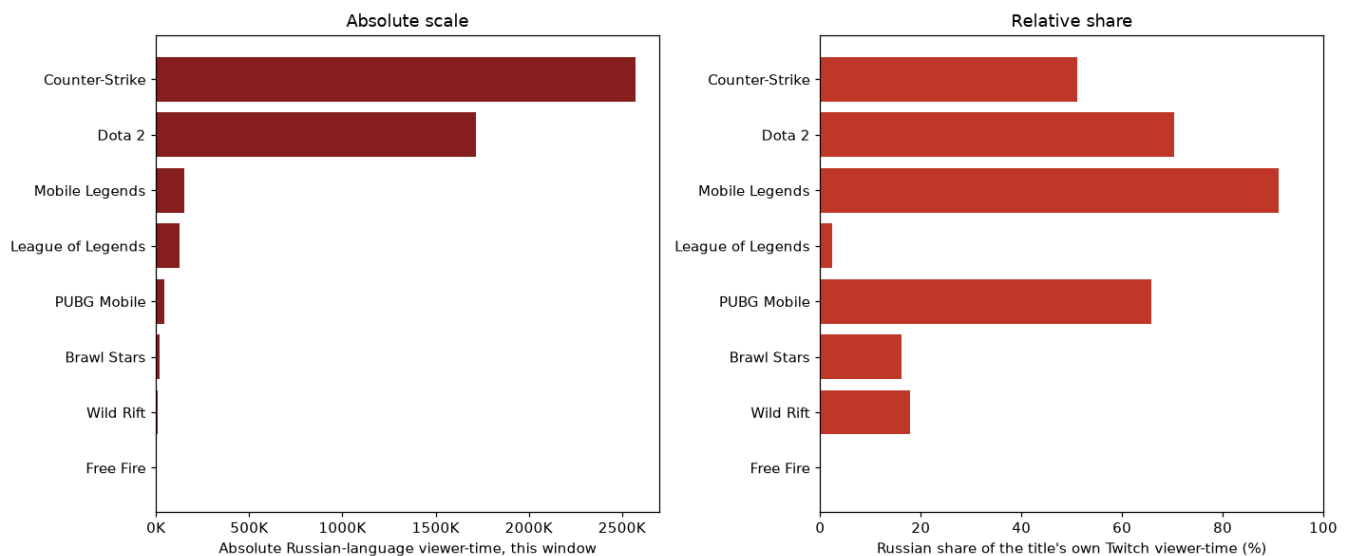
Official-broadcast-tagged: 0 (0.0%) -- 0%, expected: config/channels.yaml has no MLBB entries

Untagged, ordinary community streaming: 89.5%

## 2. Absolute scale — the part share alone can't answer

A title can be 90% Russian while still being a tiny audience overall. Checked directly, against every other language MLBB's Russian activity could be compared to, and against other titles' own Russian communities — the actual question the user asked.

|   | title             | ru_viewer_time | ru_channels | ru_peak_single_stream | title_total_viewer_time | ru_share_pct |
|---|-------------------|----------------|-------------|-----------------------|-------------------------|--------------|
| 0 | Counter-Strike    | 2570289        | 5077        | 86577                 | 5041404                 | 51.0         |
| 1 | Dota 2            | 1716154        | 5194        | 13724                 | 2438872                 | 70.4         |
| 2 | Mobile Legends    | 153148         | 422         | 2424                  | 168147                  | 91.1         |
| 3 | League of Legends | 124415         | 803         | 2196                  | 5339042                 | 2.3          |
| 4 | PUBG Mobile       | 46033          | 381         | 793                   | 69991                   | 65.8         |
| 5 | Brawl Stars       | 19122          | 186         | 1061                  | 118509                  | 16.1         |
| 6 | Wild Rift         | 6850           | 62          | 169                   | 38229                   | 17.9         |
| 7 | Free Fire         | 6              | 2           | 3                     | 7849                    | 0.1          |



**This is the central finding, and it cuts against a simple "yes it's huge" or "no it's nothing" answer.** MLBB's Russian community is real by every structural test (§1) — but in absolute terms it is **11-17x smaller** than Counter-Strike's or Dota 2's well-established Russian-speaking audiences (153K viewer-time vs. CS's 2.57M and Dota 2's 1.72M), and its single biggest Russian stream ever observed peaked at 2,424 concurrent viewers, against CS's 86,577 and Dota 2's 13,724. **MLBB's Russian community is dominant as a share of a modest title, not large in absolute terms next to this project's biggest Russian esports audiences.** Both statements are true at once, and neither alone is the full picture.

### 3. Platform-wide context — how big is Twitch's Russian gaming population overall

Using the new platform-wide collector ( `collectors/ twitch_platform_poll.py` , PRD §9.16) for the broadest denominator available: how much of *all* Russian-language Twitch activity (outside the 23 tracked esports titles) does MLBB's Russian community sit against. **Caveat stated up front, not buried:** this table currently reflects a single, partial poll (capped at `max_pages` , see `docs/ wider_game_fandom_brief.md` ), not a 9-day accumulated window like the numbers above -- a cross-section, not a matched comparison. Read it as rough scale calibration, not a precise ratio.

Non-esports Twitch, one poll: 144815 Russian viewer-time of 2139310 total (6.8%)  
Distinct Russian-language channels, non-esports Twitch, one poll: 4430

Top non-esports games by Russian viewer-time, this poll:

|                                                           |                    |               |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|---------------|
| Just Chatting                                             | viewer_time= 60318 | channels= 712 |
| Grand Theft Auto V                                        | viewer_time= 8237  | channels= 172 |
| The Blood of Dawnwalker                                   | viewer_time= 4972  | channels= 62  |
| Heroes of Might and Magic III: The Restoration of Erathia | viewer_time= 4266  | channels= 22  |
| World of Warcraft                                         | viewer_time= 3421  | channels= 132 |
| IRL                                                       | viewer_time= 2928  | channels= 36  |
| Valheim                                                   | viewer_time= 2767  | channels= 171 |
| Path of Exile 2                                           | viewer_time= 2569  | channels= 82  |
| Virtual Casino                                            | viewer_time= 2427  | channels= 4   |
| Red Dead Redemption II                                    | viewer_time= 2296  | channels= 17  |

**Read with the caveat above firmly in mind:** even in a single cross-section, **4,430 distinct Russian-language channels** were live on non-esports Twitch categories alone — MLBB's 422 Russian channels (accumulated over 9 days) are a real but small slice of a much larger Russian-speaking Twitch creator population that spans Just Chatting, GTA V, and dozens of other titles. This context cuts toward "MLBB captured a real fragment of an enormous, pre-existing Russian Twitch audience" rather than "MLBB somehow manufactured this audience itself."

## 4. Competitive infrastructure — is there real investment behind this, or is it purely organic

If MLBB's Russian community is a genuine, sustained phenomenon rather than incidental streaming, it should show up as real organized competition and sponsorship, not just viewers. Checked directly against **tournaments**, every tier, not just tier-1/2.

|    | tournament                                        | region | country | prize_pool | currency | teams | start      | end        |
|----|---------------------------------------------------|--------|---------|------------|----------|-------|------------|------------|
| 0  | MLBB Continental Championships/Season 8/Closed... | NaN    | CIS     | NaN        | NaN      | 8     | NaN        | NaN        |
| 1  | MLBB Continental Championships/Season 2           | NaN    | CIS     | 30000.0    | USD      | 8     | 2023-08-12 | 2023-10-08 |
| 2  | Games of the Future/2024                          | Europe | Russia  | 1000000.0  | USD      | 16    | 2024-02-26 | 2024-03-02 |
| 3  | MLBB Continental Championships/Season 3           | NaN    | CIS     | 40000.0    | USD      | 8     | 2024-03-30 | 2024-06-02 |
| 4  | MLBB Continental Championships/Season 4           | NaN    | CIS     | 40000.0    | USD      | 8     | 2024-08-31 | 2024-10-27 |
| 5  | MLBB Continental Championships/Season 5/Closed... | NaN    | CIS     | NaN        | NaN      | 8     | 2025-03-17 | 2025-03-18 |
| 6  | MLBB Continental Championships/Season 5           | NaN    | CIS     | 40000.0    | USD      | 8     | 2025-04-05 | 2025-06-01 |
| 7  | MLBB Continental Championships/Season 6           | NaN    | CIS     | 40000.0    | USD      | 8     | 2025-09-13 | 2025-11-16 |
| 8  | MLBB Continental Championships/Season 7/Closed... | NaN    | CIS     | NaN        | NaN      | 16    | 2026-03-21 | 2026-03-22 |
| 9  | MLBB Continental Championships/Season 7           | NaN    | CIS     | 40000.0    | USD      | 8     | 2026-04-10 | 2026-06-07 |
| 10 | BetBoom Rise of Legends/Season 10                 | NaN    | CIS     | 9000000.0  | rub      | 16    | 2026-04-16 | 2026-08-22 |
| 11 | MLBB Continental Championships/Season 8           | NaN    | CIS     | 40000.0    | USD      | 8     | 2026-08-28 | 2026-10-31 |

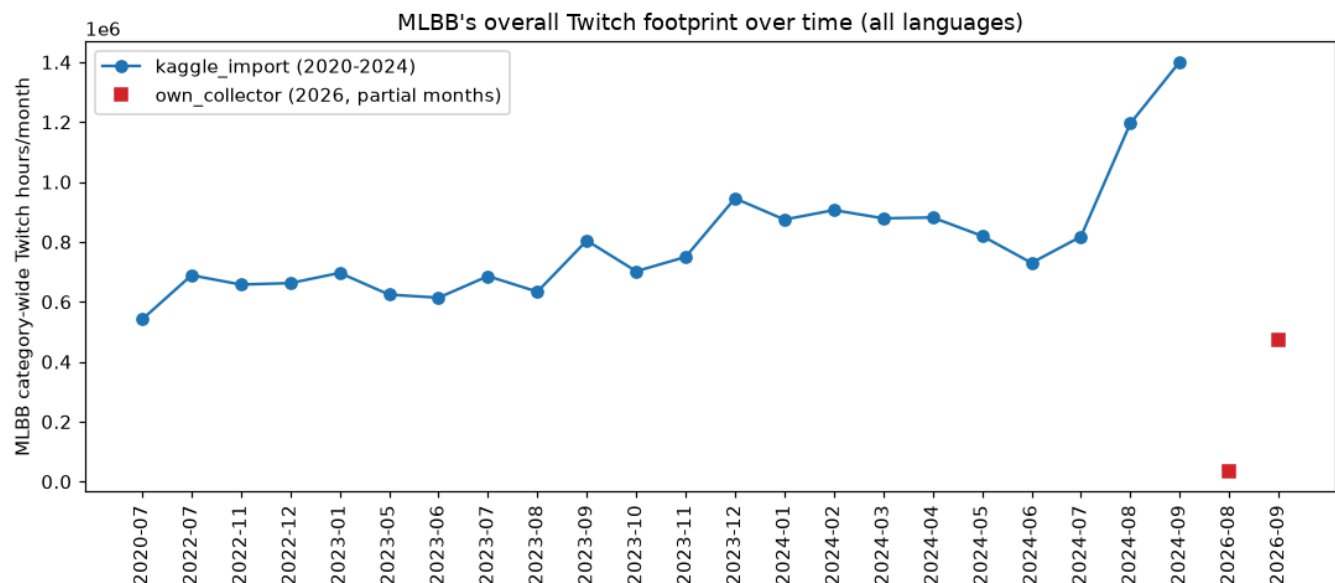
**A real, sustained, multi-year CIS competitive circuit, not a one-off event: MLBB Continental Championships** has run 8 seasons since 2023 (roughly every 4-6 months, consistently \$30-40K USD prize pools, 8 teams), including the currently-live Season 8 that first drew attention to this. **\*\*BetBoom Rise of Legends, Season 10\*\*** — BetBoom being a well-known Russian esports

sponsor/betting operator active across CS and Dota 2 too, confirmed elsewhere in this project's own tournament data — runs a ₱9,000,000 prize pool, 16 teams (currency intentionally not converted to USD here, matching this project's standing "never blend currencies" convention — see `analysis/metrics.py`'s `qualifying\_window\_scale`). A **"Season 10"** naming implies a full competitive history well before this project's own tracking window began. Separately, **"Games of the Future/2024"** — a \$1,000,000 USD, 16-team event held in Russia — is the single largest prize pool figure found anywhere in this search. **This is real institutional investment, not just organic streaming activity.**

**PUBG Mobile, MLBB's cross-title comparison point from §2, shows the same pattern at even larger scale:** `PUBG Mobile Pro League/CIS` ran \$150,000 prize pools across multiple seasons/years (2021-2022 confirmed in this dataset), 20 teams each — bigger prize pools than MLBB's own CIS circuit. Two independent mobile titles, two independent, real, multi-year CIS leagues.

## 5. Historical trajectory context (not Russia-specific, but relevant backdrop)

MLBB's overall Twitch category presence, from `monthly_category_history` — not broken out by language (the Kaggle import predates this project's own language-mix collection), but useful context for whether MLBB's Twitch footprint is itself growing, shrinking, or stable.



**MLBB's overall Twitch presence has been real and growing, not a fringe title** — 541K hours/month in 2020-07 to 1.4M by 2024-09 (the Kaggle import's last month), with an 18-month coverage gap (2024-09 to 2026-08, the same dataset-wide gap every other notebook in this project has already documented) before this project's own collection picks back up. The 2026-08/09 `own_collector` figures are partial months (collection started mid-month), not directly comparable in absolute terms.

## 6. Structure comparison — is MLBB's Russian audience broadcast-driven or organic

Different titles' Russian audiences turn out to have genuinely different internal structures, not just different sizes.

|   | title          | top10_channel_share_pct | tournament_tagged_share_pct |
|---|----------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------|
| 0 | Counter-Strike | 59.9                    | 53.3                        |
| 1 | Dota 2         | 33.2                    | 0.0                         |
| 2 | Mobile Legends | 50.9                    | 10.5                        |
| 3 | PUBG Mobile    | 34.7                    | 0.0                         |

**Counter-Strike's Russian audience is broadcast-driven** (53.3% tournament-tagged, top 10 channels are 59.9% of the total) — consistent with CS's famous large Russian-language tournament co-streams. **Dota 2 and PUBG Mobile are almost entirely organic** (0% tournament-tagged, more evenly spread across channels). **MLBB sits in between** — mostly organic (89.5% untagged) with a real but modest tournament contribution (10.5%). None of the four look like a single-event artifact; they just have different shapes.

## 7. Caveats

- **language= 'ru' is Russian-language, not confirmed Russia.** Ukraine, Belarus, and Kazakhstan all have substantial Russian-speaking populations and gaming communities — the same caveat `niche_membership.ipynb` and `title_geography_maps.ipynb` already carry for this exact language code. Nothing here separately confirms geographic Russia versus the wider Russian-speaking CIS region — and the tournament infrastructure in §4 is explicitly CIS-branded, not Russia-only, which is honest to that ambiguity rather than glossing over it.
- **Twitch-only.** Every number here is Twitch's lens on this community, not the community's true size. §3's platform-wide comparison helps calibrate scale but can't substitute for the SEA-region platforms (Facebook Gaming, regional apps) MLBB's largest real audience most likely actually watches on — genuinely out of reach for this project (PRD §9.8's Chinese-platform investigation hit the same kind of wall; no equivalent SEA-platform connector has been scoped).
- **No unique-viewer deduplication anywhere in this notebook.** `viewer_count` summed across polls is a time-weighted attention proxy, not a count of distinct people — the same convention (and the same caveat) every other viewer-time metric in this project already carries.
- **§3's platform-wide numbers are a single partial poll,** not a matched 9-day window like every other section here — stated once, applies throughout that section.
- **The whole `language_mix_snapshots` / `viewership_snapshots` window is still short** (10 days) — the daily-stability chart in §1 is reassuring against a single-event spike, but 10 days is

not a season-length baseline. Re-run this notebook once the window covers multiple months, ideally spanning an MLBB Continental Championships off-season, to see whether the Russian share holds outside any active CIS tournament at all.

## 8. Bottom line

**Not an aberration — a real, if modest, community**, on every test this notebook could run:

- Broad-based (422 distinct channels, no single channel over 8.6% of the total) and stable every day of the window (89.6%-92.1%), not a tournament-driven spike (only ~10% is tournament-tagged).
- Backed by real, sustained institutional investment — an 8-season, 3-year CIS league (MLBB Continental Championships), a major-sponsor series (BetBoom Rise of Legends, Season 10), and a \$1M event (Games of the Future 2024) — not just incidental streaming.
- Consistent with a second, independent title (PUBG Mobile) showing the same pattern even more strongly, with an even larger CIS league (\$150K PUBG Mobile Pro League/CIS) and zero tournament-broadcast contamination to explain it away.

**But "real" and "large" are different questions, and the answer to the second is more modest:**

in absolute terms, MLBB's Russian community is 11-17x smaller than this project's Counter-Strike or Dota 2 Russian audiences, and its biggest single stream ever observed peaked at a few thousand viewers, not tens of thousands. The most accurate description is a **genuine, sustained, organically-distributed, but comparatively small Russian-speaking niche community** — dominant as a share of a modest title's modest Twitch footprint, not large next to this project's biggest Russian esports audiences, and best explained as a real fragment of Twitch's much larger pre-existing Russian gaming population (§3) choosing to engage with MLBB specifically, rather than MLBB itself having an unusually large global following there.